Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

Topic 3.5 Guided Notes: Communication and Language Development

Unit 3: Development and Learning | AP Psychology

Directions: Read through the topic overview page below and fill in each blank as you go. Use the tables and activities to check your understanding, then head to the quiz link at the end to test yourself.

Source page: appsychreviewhub.com/overviews/topic3.5

Word Bank

Morphemes	*Syntax*
Semantics	*Phonemes*
Cooing	*Babbling*
Telegraphic Speech	*One-Word Speech (Holophrases)*
Grammar	*Overgeneralization*

1. The Structural Anatomy of Language

Every language requires a rigid architectural layout to transform raw sounds into complex, abstract thoughts. This structure is governed by a broad set of rules known as _____—the comprehensive system that dictates how words are structured, altered, and combined to produce meaningful communication. Psychologists split language structure into smaller, testable sub-components:

Sound and Meaning

- _____: The smallest structural units of sound in a spoken language that can be combined to form words. Altering a single sound unit can completely transform the entire word's meaning. For example, changing the “b” in the word bat to a “c” instantly creates the word cat.
- _____: The smallest units of meaning within a language. This category includes whole standalone words (like dog) as well as meaningful word fragments like prefixes and suffixes (such as the prefix un- meaning “not,” or the past-tense suffix -ed).
- _____: The branch of language study that deals directly with meaning, exploring how specific words, roots, and full sentences convey concepts, and analyzing how shifting situational contexts alter our interpretation of those messages.

Arranging the Pieces

To ensure that ideas are structured logically, language relies heavily on _____—the precise grammatical rules that dictate the required arrangement, order, and sequence of words within a sentence to build a grammatically accurate and easily understood statement (e.g., in English, adjectives generally precede nouns, such as saying “the white house”).

💡 *AP Exam Tip: To keep your study plan streamlined and efficient, note that the pragmatics of language (the social rules governing how language is interpreted in varying contexts, such as sarcasm or politeness) are explicitly outside the scope of the AP Psychology Exam!*

Apply It: Which Structural Component?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	Changing just the very first sound in the word “pat” to an “s” sound instantly creates an entirely different word, “sat.”	
2	A student explains that the word “bank” can refer to either a financial institution or the edge of a river, and only the surrounding sentence tells you which meaning is intended.	
3	A toddler says “car red” instead of “red car,” which sounds distinctly unnatural and backwards to native English speakers, since adjectives are supposed to come before the noun they describe.	
4	A linguistics teacher explains that the overall term for every single rule governing how a language's sounds, meanings, and word order combine is technically called this comprehensive system.	

2. The Chronological Stages of Language Acquisition

Long before infants can produce formal words, they actively utilize nonverbal manual gestures (such as pointing at an object or waving goodbye) to establish a communicative bridge with caregivers. As their neurological and vocal structures mature, children across all distinct cultures naturally progress through a predictable, universal timeline of speech development:

- _____ (Around 2 to 4 months): The earliest vocal milestone, characterized by soft, repetitive, vowel-like sounds such as “oo” and “ah.” These early vocalizations are unarticulated and typically reflect comfort, satisfaction, or pleasure.
- _____ (Around 4 to 10 months): A critical transition stage where infants begin rapidly producing alternating consonant-vowel combinations like “ba-ba,” “da-da,” or “ma-ma.” This phase serves as structural physical practice for speech mechanisms and initially includes sounds from global languages before narrowing down exclusively to the phonemes heard in the household.
- _____ (Around 12 months / 1 year): The stage where children begin using single, isolated words to represent entire complex thoughts or complete sentences. For instance, an infant shouting “milk!” is utilizing a single word to convey “I want a cup of milk right now.”
- _____ (Around 24 months / 2 years): Early two-word communication where toddlers speak in abbreviated, highly efficient statements containing only essential root words—primarily pairing nouns and verbs (e.g., demanding “want cookie” or stating “daddy go”). This stage is named after old-fashioned telegrams because it completely strips away non-essential fillers like articles and prepositions.

Apply It: Which Stage of Speech?

Using the word bank above, identify which stage best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Stage
1	A newborn lying peacefully in her bassinet lets out soft, drawn-out “aaah” and “oooh” sounds whenever she's calm and content, with no consonant sounds mixed in at all.	

#	Scenario	Stage
2	An 8-month-old baby repeatedly babbles “ba-ba-ba-ba” while banging a toy against his highchair tray, clearly practicing the same sound pattern over and over.	
3	A 13-month-old points at the family dog and confidently announces “doggie!” as her entire way of saying she wants to go pet it.	
4	A 2-year-old tugs on her mom's sleeve and says “more juice,” leaving out any extra words like “I want” or “please.”	

3. Grammatical Growing Pains: Overgeneralization

As children grow and their understanding of syntax expands, they actively attempt to internalize structural linguistic patterns. Because they lean heavily on universal rules before mastering structural irregularities, they frequently fall victim to _____ (sometimes called overregularization).

This language learning error occurs when a child takes a standard grammatical rule and applies it too broadly to irregular words that do not follow the guideline. Classic examples include adding standard past-tense suffixes to irregular verbs (such as saying “I goed to the park” instead of “went”) or applying plural rules incorrectly (such as declaring “I saw three mouses” instead of “mice”). These errors are highly fascinating to psychologists because they prove that children do not just blindly mimic adult speech; they actively attempt to calculate and apply internal grammatical rules!

📺 *Video Notes: “Review Video: Language” (Crash Course Psychology #16)*

Watch the video above, then answer each question below in your own words.

1. How does the video describe phonemes, morphemes, and grammar, and how does it use the word “speech” to show how they relate? What numbers does it give for English?

2. How does the video distinguish receptive and productive language, and what does it say about babbling (when it starts, what it sounds like, and what deaf babies do)?

3. According to the video, what happens to a child’s ability to hear sounds that aren’t part of their household language, and what milestones does it describe from the first birthday to age two?

4. How do Skinner and Chomsky each explain language acquisition in the video, and what does the video conclude about which view is right?

5. What is aphasia, which two brain areas does the video connect to language, and what happens when each is damaged?

6. How does the video define language, and what does the Kanzi story show about whether humans are alone in having it?

4. Don't Trip Up! (Common Misconceptions)

⚠️ Phonemes vs. Morphemes: This is a highly frequent point of confusion on the AP Exam! To protect your score, use these simple mnemonic hooks: Phoneme starts with ‘P’, just like Phone—it is strictly about the basic raw sound. Morpheme starts with ‘M’, just like Meaning—it is the smallest unit that carries an actual meaning. Remember: a single letter can sometimes be both! The word “I” is a single sound (phoneme) and it also carries distinct meaning on its own (morpheme).

5. Quick Check: Review Questions

Circle the best answer for each question below.

1. The prefix "un-" doesn't form a complete word on its own, but it carries clear, standalone meaning, transforming "happy" into "unhappy" by adding the concept of "not." This smallest unit of meaning within a language is called a:

- **A.** Phoneme
- **B.** Syntax
- **C.** Grammar
- **D.** Morpheme

2. A 3-month-old baby lying in her crib makes soft, repetitive, vowel-like sounds such as "oo" and "ahh" simply out of comfort and satisfaction, with no actual consonant sounds involved yet. This earliest vocal milestone in language development is called:

- **A.** One-Word Speech
- **B.** Telegraphic Speech
- **C.** Babbling
- **D.** Cooing

3. A 7-month-old baby is now rapidly repeating consonant-vowel combinations like "da-da-da" and "ba-ba-ba" over and over, practicing the physical mechanics of speech using sounds pulled from languages spoken all around the world, not just her own household's language yet. This stage of language development is called:

- **A.** Babbling
- **B.** One-Word Speech
- **C.** Cooing
- **D.** Telegraphic Speech

4. At around 24 months old, a toddler demands "want cookie" and later states "daddy go," stripping away all non-essential filler words like articles and prepositions in favor of an abbreviated, highly efficient statement. This stage of language development is called:

- **A.** One-Word Speech
- **B.** Telegraphic Speech
- **C.** Overgeneralization
- **D.** Babbling

5. A young child confidently declares, "I goed to the park yesterday and saw three mouses," incorrectly applying the standard past-tense "-ed" rule and the standard plural rule to two irregular words that don't actually follow those patterns. This language learning error is called:

- **A.** Babbling
- **B.** Egocentrism
- **C.** Overgeneralization
- **D.** Telegraphic Speech

✅ Check Your Progress

Done with your notes? Head over to the Quiz to test what you've learned:
https://appsychreviewhub.com/quiz

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